

Mongoose

PHYLUM	Chordata
CLASS	Mammalia
ORDER	Carnivora
FAMILY	Herpestidae
SPECIES	34

Native to warm areas of the Old World, mongooses were formerly classified with the civets in the family Viverridae, but are now classified in a separate family—the Herpestidae. Together with the Malagasy carnivores, they are thought to be closely related to hyenas.



Anatomy

Most mongooses are smaller than civets; they are shorter tailed and are more uniformly colored. Their anal scent glands are also more complex, with the scent secretion being stored in an external sac. Mongooses have elongated bodies and short legs for movement over the ground.

Snake hunters

These animals live in complex social groups and are generally active during the day. Opportunistic mongooses have a wide ranging diet that includes plant and animal material: they prey on invertebrates, small mammals, frogs, and reptiles—including snakes. It was once thought that mongooses evade envenomation by skillful maneuver when tackling snake prey, but some species have exhibited resistance to snake venom. Their effectiveness at controlling snakes and rodents led to their introduction into places as far afield as Hawaii and New Zealand—where they now pose a threat to native wildlife.

LIVING TOGETHER

Mongooses live in complex social groups, called bands, and are generally active during the day.

Cynictis penicillata

Yellow mongoose



Length	10¼–18 in (26–46 cm)
Tail	6–12 in (15–30 cm)
Weight	25–31 oz (715–900 g)
Location	Southern Africa
Social unit	Group
Status	Least concern

This mongoose is a yellowish buff color in the south of its range but grayer in the north. The family group (a breeding pair, their offspring, and nonbreeding young adults) occupies and extends a tunnel system taken over from meerkats or ground squirrels. Occasionally, these species all coexist in a large burrow. The main diet is insects, such as termites, ants, beetles, and locusts, as well as birds, eggs, frogs, lizards, and small rodents.



Helogale parvula

Dwarf mongoose



Length	6½–9 in (16–23 cm)
Tail	5½–7½ in (14–19 cm)
Weight	7–13 oz (200–350 g)
Location	E. and southern Africa
Social unit	Group
Status	Least concern

The smallest mongoose, this species has thick fur, brown but fine-grizzled in red or black, very small eyes and ears, and long-clawed front feet. It forms packs of 2–32, which “rotate” around the termite mounds of their range. They use the mound as shelter for a few days and feed on insects, lizards, snakes, birds, eggs, and mice. All members of the pack help to care for offspring, which may number up to 6 per female.



Suricata suricatta

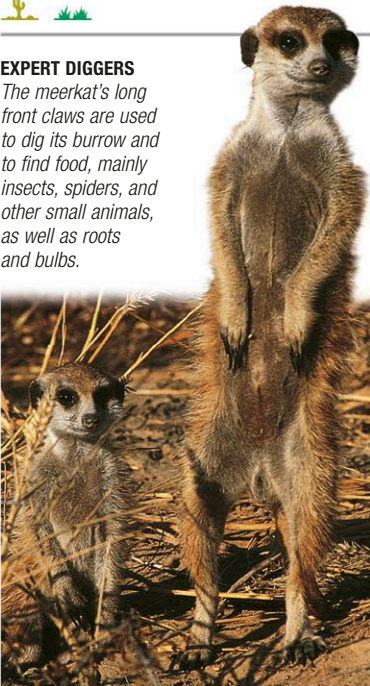
Meerkat



Length	9¾–11½ in (24.5–29 cm)
Tail	6½–10 in (17–25 cm)
Weight	21–35 oz (600–975 g)
Location	Southern Africa
Social unit	Group
Status	Least concern

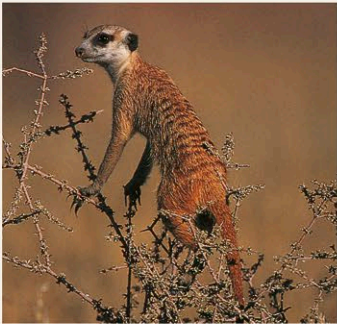
EXPERT DIGGERS

The meerkat’s long front claws are used to dig its burrow and to find food, mainly insects, spiders, and other small animals, as well as roots and bulbs.



Day-active and social, the meerkat forms colonies of about 3–20 individuals, which enlarge the former burrow systems of ground squirrels. In early morning, it emerges to sit up and sunbathe, then forages for small prey. Coloration is pale brown on the underside and face, silver-brown on the upper parts, with 8 darker bands on the rear back, dark eye rings, and a dark tip to the slender tail. After a gestation of 70 days, the 3–7 young are born in a grass-lined nursery chamber in the burrow.

ON GUARD



While most pack members forage, some act as lookout sentries, especially for hawks and other aerial predators. Sentries stand at vantage points such as on mounds and in bushes, and cheep or cluck warnings. Sharp barks or growls denote more urgent threats and the meerkats dive for cover.

Mungos mungo

Banded mongoose



Length	12–18 in (30–45 cm)
Tail	6–12 in (15–30 cm)
Weight	2–4½ lb (0.9–1.9 kg)
Location	Africa
Social unit	Variable
Status	Least concern

Common, lively, and opportunistic, this stocky mongoose has distinctive crosswise bands over the rear of the body. The fur is coarse and grizzled, and populations from moist habitats are darker brown than drier-region individuals. Often kept as a pet, the banded mongoose eats varied small items, from termites to birds’ eggs. It is often found in packs of 15–20 that include one dominant male.

about 12 bands over rump

